

THE DREYFUS AFFAIR

1894

In 1894, Alfred Dreyfus, a French army captain of Jewish faith, was falsely accused of selling secrets to Germany, on the basis of flimsy evidence. He was court-martialed for treason and imprisoned on Devil's Island in French Guiana. Fresh evidence indicating that the true culprit was Major Ferdinand Walsin-Esterhazy came to light in 1896 but was not properly explored, and he was acquitted. Growing public unease over the miscarriage of justice was stoked by novelist Émile Zola, who wrote his open letter "*J'Accuse ...!*" in support of Dreyfus. Although a document implicating Dreyfus was revealed as a forgery, a second court martial in 1899 again found Dreyfus guilty. The sentence was commuted, and Dreyfus accepted a presidential pardon. He was finally exonerated by a court of appeals in 1906.

See also: The trial of Galileo Galilei 93 ■ The Salem witch trials 104–105

THE BÜRGERLICHES GESETZBUCH

1900

After the unification of the German Empire in 1871, its former states initially retained their own varied civil laws, but the need for a single national German code of law was widely recognized. Based on Roman law, the *Bürgerliches Gesetzbuch* (*Civil Law Book*), also known as the BGB, was drafted in 1881, finally ratified in 1896, and came into law in 1900, establishing a national civil law across Germany. The BGB formed the foundation of modern German law and was used as a

model for civil law in other nations, including China, Italy, Japan, South Korea, and Switzerland.

See also: The Twelve Tables 30

■ The Napoleonic Code 130–131

THE SCOPES TRIAL

1925

After the passing of the Butler Act in Tennessee in 1925, which made it illegal to teach evolution in schools, activists were eager to refute its validity. Physics teacher John Scopes volunteered to be accused of teaching human evolution. His trial pitted anti-evolutionist William Jennings Bryan for the prosecution against celebrated attorney Clarence Darrow, allowing both sides to pitch eloquent arguments. Scopes was found guilty and fined \$100, but had achieved his and his supporters' aim of bringing debates about science versus religion into the public sphere.

See also: The trial of Galileo Galilei 93

THE MOON TREATY

1979

In a bid to ensure the international community has some jurisdiction in space, the Moon Treaty, covering the Moon and other celestial bodies, was adopted by the UN General Assembly in 1979. It states that these areas of outer space are the "common heritage of mankind" and their environment should therefore be protected. The treaty, which came into force in 1984, when Austria became the fifth country to ratify it, asks that an international group be established to regulate any future exploitation of the natural resources of the Moon or other celestial bodies. Although 18 nations

are parties to the treaty, no nation involved in human space flight has yet ratified the agreement.

See also: The World Network of Biosphere Reserves 270–271

■ The Kyoto Protocol 305

THE REPEAL OF THE APARTHEID LAWS

1991

The policy of apartheid—which segregated the South African population by race, discriminating against the black majority and favoring the white population—was put in place in 1948. In 1991, under increasing pressure from South African activists and the international community, President F. W. de Klerk repealed most of the remaining apartheid laws. These included the Land Acts of 1913 and 1936, which gave the best land to white people, and the Population Registration Act of 1950, which classified all babies by race at birth. The dismantling of the laws and the election of a government with a nonwhite majority in 1994 officially ended the apartheid system.

See also: The Nuremberg Laws 197

■ The Civil Rights Act 248–253

THE OSLO ACCORDS

1993, 1995

In a bid to secure a lasting peace between Israel and Palestine, the two Oslo Accords, negotiated initially in Norway, were signed by the Israeli government and the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) in 1993 (in Washington, DC) and 1995 (in Egypt). Earlier initiatives had included the UN Security Council Resolution 242 of 1967, adopted unanimously after the